

example: Subjects were asked which questions to ask to find out whether a person was extroverted or not, purportedly for another type of experiment. It was established that subjects supplied mostly questions for which a “yes” answer would *support* the hypothesis.

But there are exceptions. Among them figure chess grand masters, who, it has been shown, actually do focus on where a speculative move might be weak; rookies, by comparison, look for confirmatory instances instead of falsifying ones. But don’t play chess to practice skepticism. Scientists believe that it is the search for their own weaknesses that makes them good chess players, not the practice of chess that turns them into skeptics. Similarly, the speculator George Soros, when making a financial bet, keeps looking for instances that would prove his initial theory wrong. This, perhaps, is true self-confidence: the ability to look at the world without the need to find signs that stroke one’s ego.*

Sadly, the notion of corroboration is rooted in our intellectual habits and discourse. Consider this comment by the writer and critic John Updike: “When Julian Jaynes ... speculates that until late in the second millennium B.C. men had no consciousness but were automatically obeying the voices of gods, we are astounded but compelled to follow this remarkable thesis through all the corroborative evidence.” Jaynes’s thesis may be right, but, Mr. Updike, the central problem of knowledge (and the point of this chapter) is that there is no such animal as *corroborative* evidence.

Saw Another Red Mini!

The following point further illustrates the absurdity of confirmation. If you believe that witnessing an additional white swan will bring confirmation that there are no black swans, then you should also accept the statement, on purely logical grounds, that the sighting of a red Mini Cooper should confirm that there are *no black swans*.

Why? Just consider that the statement “all swans are white” is equivalent to “all nonwhite objects are not swans.” What confirms the latter statement should confirm the former. Therefore, a mind with a confirmation bent would infer that the sighting of a nonwhite object that is not a swan should bring such confirmation. This argument, known as Hempel’s raven paradox, was rediscovered by my friend the (thinking) mathematician Bruno Dupire during one of our intense meditating walks in London—one of those intense walk-discussions, intense to the point of our not noticing the rain. He pointed to a red Mini and shouted, “Look, Nassim, look! No Black Swan!”